

TOWARDS THE FRINGE
Ana Paula Maia

a translation—at what point does she rein in her interpretative voice to ensure the writer's isn't dimmed? "That's the real interest for me," Viswanathan says. "Translation, for me, is a matter of going deeper and deeper into the book until it's hard for me to tell almost where the writing is coming from. Translation has the same momentum as the process of original composition."

Set in a remote Brazilian prison raised over the bones of a former slave plantation, *On Earth as it is Beneath* drifts through a world of guards, inmates and wandering priests, where brutality festers beneath ritual and routine. Paula Maia's novel excavates violence, guilt, masculinity and the lingering afterlife of colonial power. It's a world far removed from Viswanathan's own, and it's this distance that fuels her love for amplifying the voices of underrepresented communities, like Brazilian women of colour.

SET IN A REMOTE BRAZILIAN PRISON RAISED OVER THE BONES OF A FORMER SLAVE PLANTATION, THE NOVEL DEPICTS GUARDS, INMATES AND WANDERING PRIESTS

The process is not always joyful. The thing about working with "visceral writers" like Paula Maia is that they uneasily crawl under your skin in your most vulnerable moments, but for the best possible reasons. Viswanathan couldn't avoid spending time with the character of Melquíades, the prison warden—an austere, menacing, predatory figure whose ethics have been shaped by the moral decay of the colony at large. The kind of mileage that a recognition like the Booker Prize—even in the shortlist—provides is undeniable, and a book like Paula Maia's, despite being rooted in local histories, appeals to the universal and timeless themes of discrimination and violence. So, the passage of these nine years since the original's release is irrelevant. "It could easily be a story that takes place in America," says Viswanathan—or one in India. She hopes that more written words can find homes across the world in other languages from India, where so many of her own stories come from. ■

—Arshia

HOW GREEN IS MY VALLEY

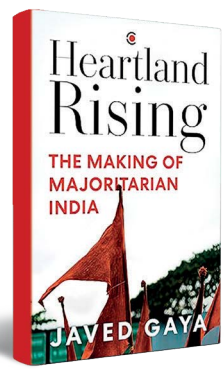
From a leading scientist, whose research focuses on tropical forests and wildlife, comes an impassioned appeal to discover nature and its denizens not just in designated national parks but simply everywhere—including our urban balconies. This is a revised edition of the book, with five new essays.



THE WILD HEART OF INDIA
By T.R. Shankar Raman
WESTLAND
₹799; 512 pages

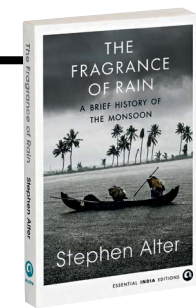
MAJORITY RULES

What are the roots of India's recent majoritarian turn? As per Javed Gaya, a Mumbai-based lawyer specialising in commercial arbitration law who has studied jurisprudence at Oxford University, the seeds were sowed during Partition itself. The book explores the weaponisation of history to India's version of secularism, recent concerns around federalism, and more.



HEARTLAND RISING
By Javed Gaya
CONTEXT
₹699; 410 pages

THE FRAGRANCE OF RAIN
By Stephen Alter
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
Rs 499; 152 pages



CHASING THE MONSOON

Here's a charming portrait of the Indian monsoon by one of our most gifted prose stylists. To his credit, Stephen Alter succeeds in giving us a deeply personal take on the subject, without straying from the brief.

—Compiled by Amit Dixit